

# Cheat or exploit?

A recent discussion (read: argument) in the Digit test labs got me thinking – are cheating and exploiting the same? We are, of course, talking in-game here. So, are they the same in the context of video games? Weelll, it's icky.

In video games, to exploit something is to utilise bugs, glitches or in-game systems and mechanics in a way not intended by the game's designers, to your advantage. Popular examples include the item duplication trick in FF7, pretty much all the Elder Scrolls games (tricks to get rich and OP quick), infinite combos in fighting games, etc. You'll notice all my examples are single player games. We'll get to that in a bit.

Cheating on the other hand does not utilise existing means, but you create your own advantage, be it by tweaking the game files, or screwing with your opponents directly in the case of competitive games. Think hacking or tampering with elements outside of the game. Messing around with game files to give yourself an advantage, trying to ruin other people's experience by targeting their connection to the game's servers; DDoS attacks basically.

And then there's cheat codes. Are they cheating? Duh. It's in the name. But it's harmless cheating since they've been added by the devs themselves, and they usually only exist in single player games.

This is where the debate gets heated. Is it cheating to use an exploit? You're using an unfair method to get an advantage in the game. However, said exploit should in theory be available for everyone to use. So, they too could get the same advantage by using the exploit. Is that cheating? It's scummy, but I don't think it's cheating. But I also think that when and where it's used is also important. I'm completely okay with harmless cheesing in single player games. What you do in your games is your business. It doesn't affect me, you do you. However, if your exploiting affects my experience, like in online



–Manish “Trigger-Happy” Rajesh  
SKOAR! Overlord | [feedback@skoar.in](mailto:feedback@skoar.in)

games, then I'm very much concerned. Is it cheating? Still no. Bannable offence? Definitely.

Using third-party software (aimbots, wall hacks, trainers), or altering game files, messing with other players' connections to get an unfair advantage, etc is blatant cheating. You don't really need an explanation to get that. If you're one of these people, you're pretty much “gamer ke naam pe dhabba” to me.

If you're a true-blue gamer who always plays by the rules and doesn't care for workarounds, then I highly doubt you're concerned about the difference between cheating and exploiting. As far as you're concerned, that's not how the game should be played, and you would be 100 percent correct. It's not.

So, what camp do you fall in? \*